

"It's mental discipline that sets one apart, the ability

Sachin Tendulkar

Cricketer 1973

BEYOND THE BOUNDARY

His greatness lies in the dignity that has accompanied him to the crease and elsewhere, in being the master of all he has surveyed, and yet, in being a true servant of the game

■ By Harsha Bhogle

When are you fully aware that you are in the midst of greatness? Does greatness have an aura, a presence about it that announces itself? Or can greatness, like with Sachin Tendulkar, be visibly manifest in one arena and be almost invisible in another? And when does it first become apparent? Is there a moment when people knock down the door that separates the good from the great? Or do they simply vapourise from one chamber and reappear in another?

It's a question I have often asked myself as I look back at the box seat I have enjoyed at the Great Tendulkar Show; watching the transition from a shy, confident schoolboy to a shy, confident megastar. He's had a lot of fun in that journey but even he can, at best, hazard a guess at how much fun it has been for us, just watching the spectacle. And so, on this journey, when did greatness first nudge him on the shoulder and gently invite him towards itself?

Was it when he was 14 and made 1,028 runs in five innings at school? Four of them not out for an average of, well, 1,028? Just for being so far ahead of anyone else that a young editor commissioned a then young writer to judge whether this cherubic kid was the greatest schoolboy cricketer ever. Was it when, at 15, instead of thinking about movies or chocolate milkshakes, he was thinking of facing Marshall, Ambrose,

Walsh and Bishop in the West Indies? Just for being disappointed at not being selected?

Was it when, at 16, having walked out to play a Test match, he had to be reminded that a bowler at this level had to be respected? When the bowlers answered to the names of Imran Khan, Wasim Akram, Waqar Younis and Aaqib Javed? Just for thinking that a bowler's job was merely to put the ball in the right place for him?

Was it when, as an authentic 17-year-old (now why do we need to put that adjective there?) he scored a century to save his team from certain defeat? Just for the sheer nonchalance of it all as he peeled off boundary after boundary and wondered why everyone else was surprised?

Was it when, not yet 18, he told his partner in that land of men, Australia, that he too would respond to the sledging after he had scored his century? Just for the sheer self-belief, for the thought itself, for providing the first indicator that he would, all his life, respond only with the bat?

Was it when, not yet 21, he had seven Test centuries behind him? At an age when people are still thinking about whether they can play a Test. Just for the sheer audacity of it all, seven Test hundreds before 21?

But hang on, we could be writing a book here. Isn't that greatness when there are so many moments of it that you cannot isolate one that truly defines it?

Does his greatness lie in that great sense of composure he seems to communicate when there is a child in him, still all excited by the idea of playing for India, by the idea of someone running up to bowl to him? Does greatness lie in remaining a child even when he is a father of two?

Or did greatness mark him out when he understood what he can do? When he saw pathways and passages for a cricket ball on a cricket ground where others only saw obstructions? When he had the confidence to sight horizons that were beyond the vision of others? Surely that has to be it. Don't some actors read words and others convey meaning from the same script?

Wasn't that greatness apparent when, at the height of the match-fixing controversy, I got a mail from a simple man: "Please tell me that Sachin is not involved. If Sachin is involved, then what is left?" For in post-liberal India he represents what an Indian can achieve and there is an inherent purity that India perceives in him.

And there is more. Close to 21 years after first meeting him, I think his greatness lies in the dignity that has accompanied him to the crease and elsewhere. In the humility with which he has conquered the game, and yet, bowed to it. In being the master of all he has surveyed, and yet, in being a servant of the game.

Yes, that is what I think it is.

The author is a well-known cricket commentator and columnist